

HOME RUN Union home minister Amit Shah on a door to door campaign in Kairana

99,694). Similarly, GSDP growth at current prices averaged 9.1 per cent in the last three years of Akhilesh's tenure, while it was only 6.4 per cent during the first three years of Adityanath's rule. To be fair, though, lower economic growth in the three years before the pandemic was a national phenomenon, not something confined to Uttar Pradesh alone.

While his economic performance presents a mixed bag due to the impact of Covid, it is Adityanath's strongarm tactics on law and order and the impression that he has brought a modicum of control over the various mafia gangs that ruled the state that are likely to get the party votes. This contrasts with the SP government's tenure that was tainted by the impression that the mafias operated freely under patronage and that corruption was rampant. The latter may be an omnipresent virus in India, but Adityanath, like Modi, is teflon-coated on this front. So far, he faces no charges of corruption, and the ascetic robes contribute to a sense of personal purity. He has also come down with a heavy hand on rioters and criminals. The policy of seizing the property of those "destroying state property" may sometimes have been seen as prone to excessive use, even if routed through the courts. But overall it worked, and traders especially breathed easy. Some of the sheen on this front was lost after the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri incident where four farmers were allegedly mowed down by a convoy of vehicles led by a Union minister's son, especially after action against him was delayed. The 2020 Hathras incident, in which a 19-year-old Dalit woman was gangraped by four dominant caste men, and later died, saw the state machinery being widely condemned for forcibly cremating her body. It remains a blotch, though Adityanath subsequently ordered a CBI inquiry into the case.

TO HIS CREDIT, ADITYANATH HAD clamped down on corruption and put his foot down on not allowing partymen to curry favours or get prized contracts. While the public lauded him for his probity, many of his own MLAs regarded him as inaccessible, arrogant and over-reliant on bureaucrats for delivery. With 44 per cent of the BJP legislators belonging to dominant castes, Adityanath, a Thakur, was accused of favouring his clansmen over Brahmins, a charge Adityanath has repeatedly denied.

A major factor that gives Adityanath and the BJP an upper hand is the strength of its organisational structure. Along with RSS support, the party has mastered the science of electioneering and built a formidable organisational machinery that has focused on grassroots management. Sunil Bansal, the BJP's astute organisational secretary who had worked under Shah to ensure the 2017 victory, is still guiding seat selection as well as campaign activity on the ground. Maurya, who was state president in 2017, says, "Our election machine has been considerably refined and improved since then. We have the tridev system at booths: the *adhyaksh*, a *prabhari* and a booth samiti. In every samiti, we have a panna pramukh who keeps an eye on 60 voters and goes to their houses and requests them to vote for us. That enables us to get our messages across to every household." The BJP also has what is its cultural trump card—the under-construction Ayodhya temple and the recently completed Kashi Vishwanath temple corridor. The power of Hindutva symbolism to earn goodwill among voters can never be discounted.

If the caste combinations Akhilesh has put together start showing results, the BJP is likely to go heavier on polarisation to consolidate the Hindu vote. Shah beginning his door-to-door campaign from Kairana, which saw communal riots break out during Akhilesh's tenure, is one signal. The other is Adityanath's "80:20" leitmotif which, despite his denials, is a clear call to religious consolidation. Akhilesh has been careful not to play into the BJP hands by overtly supporting the Muslim community. He says, "I don't think polarisation is going to happen because people are fed up with unemployment and inflation. They want an alternative. If we form the government in 2022, I will work at double the speed and that will triple the economy." Adityanath too ultimately backs everything with an economic promise. He promises to turn UP into a trillion-dollar economy (it currently stands at Rs 17.4 lakh crore and will have to grow by four times to achieve that status) in his second term, which he says will double the per capita income of its people. His message to Akhilesh: "Be prepared to face a decimating defeat on March 10." But if things don't go as planned for the BJP, he needs to be prepared too—for a return to mahanthood. ■